

# Vision

**Mission:** kairos exists to give every student access to the college guidance they deserve, regardless of whether they can afford a private counselor.

**kairos is a platform built around two core use cases:**

**Students who want clarity and a path forward**

- kairos generates a personalized timeline based on each student's grades, goals, and interests, giving them a concrete starting point and a clear picture of what's possible
- Students log their progress directly in kairos, which continuously adapts their plan and keeps them organized throughout the admissions process
- Target audience: high schoolers navigating college admissions without access to a private counselor

**Counselors who need a smarter way to support students**

- The American School Counselor Association recommends a 250:1 counselor-to-student ratio; the U.S. average is 372:1, meaning counselors are stretched far too thin
- As a result, most counselors are focused on keeping students on track to graduate, not on maximizing their college potential
- Counselor information is often scattered across tools, emails, and spreadsheets, creating inefficiency and frustration
- kairos centralizes everything, freeing counselors to focus on students who are actively pursuing college and helping schools improve their overall admission rates

**What kairos is not:** a tutoring platform, a homework tool, or a social network. kairos is focused exclusively on college readiness and the admissions journey.

# Timeline

## kairos ROADMAP: FOUNDATION TO FIRST SIGNED CLIENT

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### **PHASE 1: Foundation** — June 15 to June 29

- ~~Finalize master document~~
  - ~~Conduct 2 to 3 counselor interviews and 5 to 7 student interviews~~
  - ~~Define MVP feature set based on interview findings~~
  - ~~Map core user flow on paper or Figma before writing any code~~
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### **PHASE 2: Build MVP** — June 30 to August 10

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### **PHASE 3: First Demo** — August 11 to August 24

- Identify one school where you have a personal connection
  - Prepare a 10-minute demo: student flow first, then counselor view
  - Collect feedback, take notes, and iterate on the product
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### **PHASE 4: Pilot Conversation** — August 25 to September 14

- Return to the same school with a refined demo and a one-page pitch
  - Propose a free pilot: one semester, no cost, in exchange for feedback and a testimonial
  - Get a verbal commitment from a principal or counselor
- 

### **PHASE 5: Formalize and Sign** — September 15 to October 5

- Draft a simple one-page pilot agreement outlining the terms of the free pilot
- Get it signed
- First client signed by October 5

# Interviews

12 people total:

- 4 with no resources
- 4 with some resources
- 4 with everything they need

4 With No College Counselor:

- ~~Tahir~~
- ~~Jake~~
- Tovi (Planned)
- ~~Caroline~~

4 Who Have Dropped/Switched Counselors:

- Zahara (Messaged)
- 
- 

4 With A College Counselor:

- Ahana (Messaged)
- ~~Ayaan (Messaged)~~
- ~~Ariana~~
- Zahara (Messaged)

Patterns Across Interviews (4 of 12 complete)

- Everyone wants personalization based on their actual stats and goals, not generic advice
- The real pain point is direction, not information. Students don't lack resources, they lack a clear next step
- Trust must be earned before adoption. Every interviewee said they need proof the platform works before relying on it
- A platform is seen as a supplement to a human counselor, not a replacement
- Multiple interviewees independently asked for the same core features: school match percentages, a step-by-step plan, and essay help

**Interviewee Message:**

I'm working on a research idea and was wondering if I could ask you a few questions about your experience with the college application process? It'll only take like 15 to 20 minutes. Let me know if you're down.

### **Interview Questions:**

#### **No College Counselor:**

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - Have you started thinking about college applications yet?

- How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?
- What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?
- What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?
- If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?
- Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?
- What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time

### **Dropped/Switched Counselors:**

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - How long did you work with your counselor before you decided to leave or switch?



- What was the main reason you dropped or switched? What was the breaking point?
- Looking back, what did you actually need that your counselor wasn't providing?
- What did your counselor do well, if anything?
- After leaving, how did you handle the process on your own? Was it harder, easier, or about the same?
- If you were using a platform instead of a human counselor, what would it need to do to keep you from abandoning it?
- 
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time

### **With A College Counselors:**

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - How did you find your counselor, and how long have you been working with them?

- What does a typical session with your counselor look like? What do you actually spend time on?
  - What does your counselor do that you genuinely couldn't do on your own?
  - What do you wish your counselor did better or differently?
  - How organized is the process? Do you feel like you always know what to do next, or is it still confusing at times?
  - If a platform could handle some of what your counselor does, which parts would you be comfortable handing off to a tool?
  - What would a platform need to offer for you to consider it a real alternative or supplement to your counselor?
- 
- Wrapup:
    - Anything else they want to talk about?
    - Thank them for their time

# Ariana Interview

## **With A College Counselors:**

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - How did you find your counselor, and how long have you been working with them?
  - What does a typical session with your counselor look like? What do you actually spend time on?
  - What does your counselor do that you genuinely couldn't do on your own?
  - What do you wish your counselor did better or differently?
  - How organized is the process? Do you feel like you always know what to do next, or is it still confusing at times?
  - If a platform could handle some of what your counselor does, which parts would you be comfortable handing off to a tool?
  - What would a platform need to offer for you to consider it a real alternative or supplement to your counselor?
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time

- **How did you find your counselor, and how long have you been working with them?**
  - Had her counselor since the beginning of 8th grade
  - Wanted to apply to a private high school
- **What does a typical session with your counselor look like? What do you actually spend time on?**
  - Leading up to junior year, it was only 2-3 times a year
    - Talking about how her classes went, what classes she needs to take, what extracurriculars she needs to take
  - Helped with the recruitment process
  - A lot of her friends used counselors for their essays/supplementals
- **What does your counselor do that you genuinely couldn't do on your own?**
  - Counselor explained what colleges are looking for
  - Felt like she could trust the counselors advice because she has a lot of experience
  - Essentially provided clarity on what they're looking for in essays
    - Doesn't feel like you can find it online
- **What do you wish your counselor did better or differently?**
  - She wishes her counselor knew more about sports
  - Was surprised she didn't know much about recruitment considering how many athletes she worked with
  - Wishes she was more involved in the community
    - Doesn't think the counselor knew much about the local options
- **How organized is the process? Do you feel like you always know what to do next, or is it still confusing at times?**
  - Pretty organized for both her and her friends
  - She creates a whole timeline and schedule in advance
  - Always knew what to do next
- **If a platform could handle some of what your counselor does, which parts would you be comfortable handing off to a tool?**
  - Creating a schedule for her
  - Revising your supplementals
    - Essay help
  - She would trust the platform 99% to revise the essays well

- **What would a platform need to offer for you to consider it a real alternative or supplement to your counselor?**
  - Comfort
    - Comes in the form of a lot of information on a wide range of schools

# Caroline Interview

## No College Counselor:

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - Have you started thinking about college applications yet?
  - How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?
  - What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?
  - What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?
  - If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?
  - Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?
  - What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time



- **Have you started thinking about college applications yet?**
  - Yes
  - Just thinking that college applications are going to be hard
- **What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?**
  - Doesn't need one yet
  - Because she's going to be a freshman
  - Planning on getting one mid-sophomore or end of sophomore year
- **How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?**
  - Not thinking about the college application process
  - Trying to push herself academically by taking harder classes
- **What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?**
  - How she's going to pick what types of schools she wants to apply to
  - Has a rough idea, but nothing concrete about her major/field of interest
- **If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?**
  - Nice to have something that is personalized to you based on location, what college is right for her
  - Input weather, location, major, big/small, etc
    - Spits out a list of ~10 schools to apply to
  - Would definitely use that app
- **Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?**
  - Would definitely use it if its free
  - She would use the app for \$15 a month
- **What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?**
  - Wouldn't trust it over a college counselor
  - Wouldn't seriously use it
  - Wouldn't use it side-by-side with a college counselor
  - Would only trust it if proven
    - Eg. If it has helped 40k+ students in the past year

# Jake Interview

## No College Counselor:

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - Have you started thinking about college applications yet?
  - How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?
  - What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?
  - What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?
  - If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?
  - Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?
  - What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time

- **Have you started thinking about college applications yet?**
  - Yes, started YMSL to get community service hours for his resume
  - Trying to get a 4.0 and take harder classes
- **How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?**
  - His two siblings have gone through this
  - His parents are helping him
  - These 4 people are being his counselor
- **What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?**
  - Currently in freshman year
  - His siblings got it in junior year
  - He feels it's not too important right now
- **What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?**
  - Academics themselves
    - Taking harder classes
  - Other people asking you all the time what your plan is
  - The scale of it right now
    - There's so many things that can go wrong
- **If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?**
  - Something that could give you a step-by-step process
  - Something to narrow it down and tell him what to do instead of guessing
- **Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?**
  - Some way to understand what to pick
    - Essentially an AI agent
  - A good UI
- **What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?**
  - He would use it if he had proof that it works at a high level
  - If it's not something he can fully trust then he'd look to other resources

# Tahir Interview

## No College Counselor:

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - Have you started thinking about college applications yet?
  - How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?
  - What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?
  - What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?
  - If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?
  - Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?
  - What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time

- **Have you started thinking about college applications yet?**
  - Yes
  - Focusing on what schools he would like to get into/apply into
  - Different merits: good grades and extracurriculars
- **How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?**
  - Trying to find what passions he has (future plans)
  - His Dad helps him out by exposing him to his job as a CFO
- **What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?**
  - Too early
  - Don't want to be paying that much for the whole 4 years
- **What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?**
  - Narrowing down what to focus on and what he wants to do in the future
- **If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?**
  - Set up mock careers and show him the path for what fields he's interested in
- **Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?**
  - He would use it
  - Seeing what colleges he could get into is an important feature
  - Input grades, ECs, etc.
    - See your chances and the steps you need to take to get into your chosen school
    - Maybe gives different projects or classes that you should do
- **What would make you trust a tool like this enough to actually use it regularly?**
  - Has to have reviews
  - Needs to be tried and true
  - Otherwise would be willing to use it, if it has been explained to him in depth
  -

# Ayaan Interview



## **With A College Counselors:**

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - How did you find your counselor, and how long have you been working with them?
  - What does a typical session with your counselor look like? What do you actually spend time on?
  - What does your counselor do that you genuinely couldn't do on your own?
  - What do you wish your counselor did better or differently?
  - How organized is the process? Do you feel like you always know what to do next, or is it still confusing at times?
  - If a platform could handle some of what your counselor does, which parts would you be comfortable handing off to a tool?
  - What would a platform need to offer for you to consider it a real alternative or supplement to your counselor?
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time

- **How did you find your counselor, and how long have you been working with them?**
  - He found his counselor through a family member
  - Two years, the beginning of freshman year
- **What does a typical session with your counselor look like? What do you actually spend time on?**
  - How school is going
  - Grades
  - Summer plans (Courses, SAT, upcoming classes)
  -
- **What does your counselor do that you genuinely couldn't do on your own?**
  - Nothing he couldn't do, but stuff that would take a lot of time
    - Finding specific courses
    - Building a narrative
- **What do you wish your counselor did better or differently?**
  - That she double checks information
    - Had recommended a science fair that didn't apply to him
- **How organized is the process? Do you feel like you always know what to do next, or is it still confusing at times?**
  - Pretty organized
  - Most of the time he feels as if he knows what to do next
  - It is confusing, when provided with incorrect information
- **If a platform could handle some of what your counselor does, which parts would you be comfortable handing off to a tool?**
  - Would be comfortable handing off everything his counselor does to a tool
- **What would a platform need to offer for you to consider it a real alternative or supplement to your counselor?**
  - It needs to prove itself
    - Number of users?
  - Test it for himself (if he's blown away) or find out that its been used by a lot of people
    - Would be blown away if it provides a path to build a narrative

# Tovi Interview

## No College Counselor:

- Introduce yourself
- Thank them for their time
- Tell them a little bit about the topic
  - "So basically, I'm building a platform called kairos. The idea is that right now, getting real guidance through the college admissions process is kind of a privilege. If your family can afford a private counselor, you get a personalized plan, someone keeping you on track, and a clear sense of what to do next. If you can't, you're pretty much on your own.
  - kairos is trying to fix that. It's a platform that gives students a personalized admissions timeline based on their grades, goals, and interests, and it also gives school counselors a better way to keep track of all their students in one place.
  - I'm still in the early stages, so I haven't built anything yet. That's actually why I'm talking to you today. I want to understand your experience before I build anything, so I'm building the right thing."
- Ask if I can record the session
- Warmup:
  - Tell me a little bit about yourself
    - Interests and hobbies
- Body:
  - Have you started thinking about college applications yet?
  - How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?
  - What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?
  - What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?
  - If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?
  - Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?
  - What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?
- Wrapup:
  - Anything else they want to talk about?
  - Thank them for their time

- **Have you started thinking about college applications yet?**
  - He has started thinking about college applications
  - The whole process
  - What components are the most important
  - Talked to many people about the process
  - Focuses on writing
  
- **How are you currently navigating the college application process? What resources are you using?**
  - Trying to find his passion
  - Trying to find his niche
  - His parents are helping him out
  
- **What is the main reason you don't have a college counselor?**
  - Because he hasn't seeked one out
    - He feels like he doesn't need the advice at this point
  
- **What part of the process feels the most overwhelming or confusing right now?**
  - The competition can be very overwhelming
  - Finding that one thing that he's very good at
  
- **If a tool could do one thing to make this easier for you, what would it be?**
  - Easily lay out the basic things you need for an individual college
    - What do colleges expect from students
  - Lot of people want a baseline knowledge
  
- **Would you use a free platform that gave you a personalized college admissions timeline based on your grades, goals, and interests?**
  - Depending on how good it is
  - Doesn't know how heavily he'd use it
  - Definitely would check it out
  
- **What would make you trust a tool like that enough to actually use it regularly?**
  - Proven results
  - Would want to see at least 100 students helped
    - "Currently serving 100+ students"

# Interview Synthesis

## Interview Synthesis

Ariana - Has had a counselor since 8th grade, trusts her a lot, especially for essay advice. Wishes she knew more about sports recruiting. Would let a tool handle scheduling and essay edits.

Caroline - No counselor yet, too early (freshman). I want an app that suggests schools based on her preferences. Would use it for free, maybe pay \$15/month, but wouldn't trust it over a real counselor.

Jake - No counselor, feels overwhelmed by how big and confusing the process is. I want something that just tells him what to do next instead of guessing. Needs proof it works before trusting it.

Tahir - No counselor, mainly because of cost. Wants to see his odds at schools based on his grades/activities. Would trust a tool if it has reviews or a good track record.

Ayaan - Has a counselor for 2 years, but she gave him bad advice once, which hurt his trust in her. Says he'd actually let a tool do everything his counselor does, if it proves itself.

Tovi - No counselor, hasn't looked for one. Feels overwhelmed by competition and not knowing his "thing." Wants a simple breakdown of what colleges expect. Low bar for trust, just wants proof it's helped some students.

## Top 3 Patterns

1. Nobody trusts a tool right away. Everyone wants proof first, like "helped 40k students," reviews, or a track record.
2. The real problem is not knowing what to do next, not lack of info. Most kids already have some help (parents, siblings, google), they just want something to point them in a clear direction.
3. People see it as a helper, not a replacement, unless their counselor lets them down (like Ayaan), in which case they're open to doing everything.

# Problem Validation



## [Problem Validation](#)

### Market Research Report — Team kairos Team Members: Ari

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#### Problem Statement

Millions of high school students navigating the college admissions process lack access to personalized guidance, while overworked school counselors are too stretched to fill that gap. This creates a system where a student's college outcome is largely determined by whether their family can afford private counseling.

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#### Problem Description

The college admissions process is one of the most consequential and complex experiences a young person faces, yet most students receive almost no individual guidance through it. Public school counselors are responsible for hundreds of students at a time, leaving little room for meaningful college advising. Meanwhile, private counselors cost hundreds to thousands of dollars, making them inaccessible to the majority of families. The students who suffer most are first-generation and low-income students, who are already navigating the process without any family roadmap. Without structured guidance and organization, these students are left to figure out a high-stakes process entirely on their own.

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#### Research Findings

- According to the U.S. Department of Education's NCES, the national student-to-school counselor ratio was 372:1 in the 2024-2025 school year, well above the ASCA's recommended ratio of 250:1. [School Counselor Roles & Ratios](#)
- Due to the counselor-to-student ratio and limited school year time, a public high school student can expect an average of just 44 minutes per year of admissions advice from their school counselor. [The newest benefit at top companies: Private college admissions counseling](#)
- Private college counseling typically costs around \$140 an hour according to the Independent Educational Consultants Association, with comprehensive packages ranging from \$300 to \$600 per hour or more, placing them out of reach for most families. [Posted in Guidance Gap The newest benefit at top companies: Private college admissions counseling](#) / [How Much Do College Counselors Charge in 2026? \\$200 to](#)

### \$10,000+ Exposed

- Nationally, an estimated 8 million students have no access to a school counselor at all, according to The Education Trust. [Mapped: America's critical shortage of school counselors](#)
- According to a 2018 study from the Pell Institute, only 11% of students from the lowest-income quartile earn bachelor's degrees within six years, compared to 58% of students from the highest-income groups. [First-Generation, Low-Income | Close the Gap Foundation](#)
- First-generation students are twice as likely to leave college without completing a bachelor's degree than their peers, even when they come from higher-income backgrounds and arrive academically prepared. [Contextualizing Completion Gaps for First-Generation Students](#)
- A study by the National Bureau of Economic Research found that low-income students are often steered toward less-selective colleges even when they have the academic qualifications to attend more prestigious institutions. [RISE-Pocket Counselor](#)

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## **Validation Techniques**

To validate this problem, a combination of secondary research, interviews, and observational methods would be used. Secondary research was drawn from credible sources including ASCA, the U.S. Department of Education's NCES, the Education Trust, the Pell Institute, and the Hechinger Report, all of which confirm the counselor shortage and the equity gap in college access. For primary research, surveys would be conducted with high school juniors and seniors across public schools, asking about their awareness of the college admissions timeline, how much time they've spent with their school counselor on college topics, and whether they feel prepared. Interviews would be conducted with school counselors directly to understand their workflows, pain points, and what tools they currently use to track student progress. Observational research would involve sitting in on college advising sessions or studying how counselors currently manage student caseloads. These methods are appropriate because they capture the problem from all three angles kairos serves: the student who lacks guidance, the counselor who lacks tools, and the institution that needs a better solution.

# Market Research + Business Proposal Development

## Market Research + Business Proposal Development

### **Assignment 3: Market Research Report and Business Proposal Development Team**

**Name:** kairos **Team Members:** Ari

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#### **Part 1: Executive Summary**

##### **Business Concept**

kairos is an AI-powered college counseling platform that gives every high school student access to personalized admissions guidance, regardless of their family's income or their school's resources. The platform serves students, school counselors, and school administrators through a unified dual-dashboard system that integrates directly into existing learning management platforms like Canvas and Schoology.

##### **Problem Statement**

High school students across America are navigating one of the most consequential decisions of their lives with almost no individualized support. School counselors are severely overloaded, and private college counseling is priced out of reach for the majority of families. The result is a system where a student's college outcome is largely determined by their family's wealth, not their potential.

##### **Solution**

kairos provides AI-driven, personalized admissions guidance to students while giving counselors a centralized dashboard to track and support their entire caseload. Schools license kairos as a platform-wide tool, integrating it into the systems students and counselors already use every day.

##### **Unique Value Proposition**

Unlike traditional college counseling services that cost thousands of dollars per family, and unlike existing tools that focus narrowly on record-keeping or college databases, kairos delivers the full counseling experience: personalized timelines, major exploration, scholarship matching, application tracking, and counselor workflow tools, all within a single affordable platform.

##### **Ideal Customer Profile**

Primary Customers (Buyers): Public high schools, charter schools, and school districts

Decision Makers: School counselors, college and career readiness coordinators, principals, and district administrators

End Users: High school students ages 14 to 18, with a focus on first-generation applicants and students from low- and middle-income families attending schools with limited counseling resources

Psychographic Profile: Schools value improved college enrollment rates, efficient counselor workflows, and affordable edtech solutions. Students value personalized guidance, clarity in the application process, reduced stress, and a real shot at college acceptance.

### **First-Year Goals**

- Partner with 10 schools, primarily in one region where in-person outreach is feasible
  - Support 5,000 students
  - Generate \$50,000 to \$75,000 in annual recurring revenue
  - Increase FAFSA completion and scholarship application rates at all partner schools
- 

## **Part 2: Concept and Services**

### **Product Description**

kairos is a cloud-based SaaS platform with two core interfaces: a student-facing dashboard and a counselor-facing dashboard. It integrates directly into existing learning management systems like Canvas and Schoology so students can access it where they already spend their time, and counselors can manage their entire caseload from one place.

### **Core Features**

AI College Match Tool: Generates personalized reach, target, and safety school lists based on a student's GPA, course history, extracurriculars, awards, career interests, budget preferences, and goals. Includes ED/EA strategy recommendations and acceptance rate data.

Major and Career Discovery Tool: Students complete interest assessments to identify academic strengths and potential majors. The platform explains degree requirements, career paths, salary expectations, and top colleges for each major.

Scholarship Matching Engine: Automatically surfaces merit-based, need-based, local, and diversity scholarships relevant to each student's profile.

Personalized Admissions Timeline: Generates a step-by-step, deadline-driven roadmap tailored to each student's grade level, target schools, and goals. Updates dynamically as students log progress.

Application Management Dashboard: Tracks college application deadlines, FAFSA deadlines, scholarship deadlines, and essay submissions in one place.

AI Essay Coach: Provides structured feedback on college essay drafts including story clarity, structure, and admissions readiness.

Counselor Dashboard: Gives counselors a bird's-eye view of all student progress, flags at-risk students, and allows counselors to send reminders and prioritize outreach efficiently.

### **Premium Services**

- Counselor training and onboarding support
- Custom reporting dashboards for administrators
- Virtual admissions workshops
- Essay review by admissions professionals

### **Delivery Method**

kairos is delivered as a web-based application, mobile-friendly and accessible via a dedicated tab within Canvas, Schoology, or similar platforms. Schools purchase a school-wide license with annual renewals.

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## **Part 3: Mission, Vision, and Goals**

### **Mission Statement**

To give every student access to the college guidance they deserve, regardless of whether they can afford a private counselor.

### **Vision Statement**

A future where a student's college outcome is determined by their potential, not their zip code or family income.

### **First-Year Goals**

- Acquire 10 school partnerships, concentrated in one region to keep outreach manageable
  - Reach 5,000 active student users with a monthly active usage rate above 60%
  - Achieve 90% counselor satisfaction among partner schools, measured via end-of-year survey
- 

## **Part 4: Unique Value Proposition**

### **What Makes kairos Different**

Most existing platforms address one piece of the puzzle. Naviance focuses on college planning but lacks meaningful personalization. Scoir modernizes the application process but does not offer guidance. CollegeVine provides strong resources but is consumer-facing and lacks counselor workflow tools. None of them integrate natively into the school's existing learning platform.

kairos is the only platform that combines personalized AI admissions guidance, scholarship matching, major exploration, application tracking, and counselor workflow tools into a single school-licensed solution that lives inside the tools students and counselors already use.

### **Benefits for Schools**

- Improved college readiness outcomes without hiring additional staff
- Centralized, data-driven visibility into student progress
- A tangible tool for boosting college enrollment and scholarship award rates

### **Benefits for Students**

- A personalized, 24/7 digital college counselor
- Clarity on where to apply, what to study, and how to pay for it
- Reduced stress and a clear, organized path forward

### **Benefits for Counselors**

- All student information in one place, ending the frustration of scattered records
- Ability to focus time on high-need students rather than administrative tasks
- A tool that makes their job genuinely easier and their impact measurably greater

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## **Part 5: Market Analysis**

### **Industry Overview**

The U.S. edtech market was valued at \$83.7 billion in 2025 and is projected to reach \$241.1 billion by 2034, growing at a compound annual growth rate of 12.1%. K-12 represents the largest segment of the global edtech market at 56.1% of total share. High school applications specifically account for approximately 27% of the K-12 edtech market, driven by college readiness programs and advanced learning tools. AI-powered personalization and counselor shortage solutions are among the fastest-growing sub-segments within this space.

### **Target Market**

Primary Market: Public high schools, charter schools, and school districts across the United States. There are approximately 27,000 public high schools in the U.S., the vast majority of which are underserved by existing college counseling solutions.

Secondary Market: College access nonprofits, educational youth development organizations, and college access programs serving first-generation students.

### **Competitor Analysis**

Naviance: Widely adopted and well-known. Strengths include strong school relationships and college planning tools. Weaknesses include a dated user experience, limited AI personalization, and no meaningful integration into day-to-day learning platforms.

Scoir: A modern college application platform with clean school integration. Weakness is a narrow focus on application management with little actual guidance or counseling functionality.

CollegeVine: Strong consumer-facing admissions content and chancing tools. Weakness is that it is primarily student-facing with no counselor workflow capabilities, making school adoption difficult.

### **Market Gap**

No existing platform combines personalized AI-driven guidance, counselor workflow tools, and native LMS integration into a single school-licensed product. kairos fills that gap specifically for the schools and students who need it most but have historically been underserved.

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## **Part 6: Financial Plan**

### **Estimated Startup Costs**

- Software Development: \$30,000
- AI Integration: \$15,000
- UX/UI Design: \$5,000
- Marketing and School Outreach: \$10,000
- Legal and Business Formation: \$3,000
- Operations and Software Tools: \$2,000

Total Estimated Startup Costs: \$65,000

### **Initial Funding Requirement**

\$75,000

Potential Sources: Education-focused grants, angel investors, startup competitions, and accelerator programs focused on edtech or social impact.

### **Revenue Model**

Annual School Licenses:



- Small School (under 500 students): \$5,000/year
- Medium School (500 to 1,500 students): \$7,500/year
- Large School (1,500+ students): \$15,000/year
- District License: \$25,000 to \$100,000/year (target for year two and beyond)

Premium Add-Ons: Counselor training, custom analytics dashboards, admissions workshops, and parent engagement tools.

### **Team Roles**

Software Developer, Product Designer, Marketing and Sales Lead, Education Advisor, Customer Success Manager

### **First-Year Financial Projections**

- Total Expenses: \$75,000
- Projected Revenue: \$50,000 to \$75,000 (10 school partnerships, primarily small to medium schools at \$5,000 to \$7,500 per license)
- Projected Net: Near breakeven or a modest loss, which is expected and acceptable for a first-year edtech startup establishing its initial customer base
- Year Two ARR Target: \$200,000 to \$300,000 as partnerships expand and district-level conversations mature

# MVP Features

## MVP Features (v1, revised)

### Personalized Onboarding Profile — Free

- Students input GPA, grade level, interests, extracurriculars, location and school preferences, and college goals
- Profile gracefully handles incomplete information. If a field like intended major is left blank, the match list still generates using available data (GPA, grade level, location), and the platform shows a small honest note like "Add your intended major for more precise matches" rather than silently guessing
- Students can update unknown or evolving fields at any time, with gentle inline nudges over time rather than forced prompts, since younger students often don't have concrete answers yet

### School Match List (Reach, Target, Safety) — Free

- Generates a curated list of schools based on the student's stats, preferences, and goals, including estimated chances of admission
- Each school includes a "why this school" tag and a tappable percentage breakdown sub-tab showing the actual factors behind the number: GPA relative to that school's typical accepted range, course rigor, extracurricular strength, and major fit, each shown with a simple visual indicator
- If any factor is missing due to an incomplete profile, the breakdown transparently shows which inputs were unavailable rather than fabricating confidence
- AI regeneration of the list capped at 3 per week on Free, unlimited on Premium

### Major and Career Path Explorer (sub-screen of School Match List) — Premium

- Shows potential majors tied to each matched school, with a mock career path attached
- Includes real data points like median salaries or employment rates

### AI-Generated Admissions Timeline (separate dashboard) — Free (logistics) / Premium (strategic advice)

- Free tier shows the purely logistical timeline: deadlines, requirements, and dates merged across all matched schools, with a "you are here" marker
- The "you are here" marker prioritizes the nearest upcoming deadline, with ties broken by which deadline affects the most schools. Strategic, non-dated advice items never claim the "you are here" position, since they're longer-horizon and shouldn't crowd out time-sensitive logistics
- Premium unlocks the proactive, profile-based strategic advice layer, tailored recommendations like which classes to take or what internships to pursue based on grade level and intended major. This is the platform's most differentiated feature and the clearest reason to upgrade
- Students can check off completed items on either tier, syncing automatically to the student

profile

Essay and Supplemental Feedback Tool (separate dashboard) — Premium

- Structured AI feedback trained to challenge the student's writing directly rather than offering surface-level praise
- Tone requires careful testing with real students before launch, given the sensitivity of feedback on personal writing

Upgrade Screen (Free vs Premium Comparison) — its own dedicated tab

- Side-by-side comparison of Free and Premium features
- Monthly (\$12/month) and annual (\$120/year) options presented as separate clear choices
- Surfaced contextually when a free user hits a limit or taps into a premium-only feature like strategic timeline advice or essay feedback

Counselor Dashboard — included in MVP

Note on account model: kairos has two distinct account types in this build: students and counselors. Students go through the onboarding flow described above. Counselors log in separately and are linked to a `school_id` at registration, which determines which students they can see. Counselor accounts are not subject to Free/Premium tier gating; access is determined at the school license level. The two account types share the same Supabase Auth system but route to entirely different interfaces after login.

Screen C1: Counselor Home — Student Roster Overview

The counselor's landing screen after login. A bird's-eye view of their entire caseload.

Layout:

- A header stat strip showing: total students assigned, number with incomplete profiles, number with no active school match list yet, number with at least one overdue timeline item
- A filterable, sortable student list. Each row shows: student name, grade level, GPA, number of active matched schools, number of incomplete timeline items, and a status badge

Status badge logic (implement exactly as specified):

- "On Track": student has a complete profile, at least one active school match, and no overdue logistics timeline items
- "Needs Attention": student has an overdue logistics deadline, an incomplete profile with no activity in 14+ days, or zero active school matches after completing onboarding
- "No Activity": student completed onboarding but has not logged in within the past 30 days

Filtering: by grade level, by status badge, by college goal keyword (free text search against the `college_goals` field)

Sorting: by nearest upcoming deadline (default), by last login date ascending, by GPA ascending or descending

Tapping a student row navigates to Screen C2.

#### Screen C2: Student Detail View

A read-only counselor view of an individual student's full profile and progress. Counselors cannot edit student data directly; they can view and annotate.

Four tabs:

Tab A — Profile: mirrors the student's Screen 8 (Resume View) exactly. Shows which fields are still empty with a subtle warning indicator.

Tab B — School Matches: lists all active school\_matches rows for this student, same Reach/Target/Safety groupings and percentage display as Screen 3. Counselors can see the why\_text and factors breakdown. Read-only; counselors cannot add or remove schools in this MVP.

Tab C — Timeline: full read-only view of the student's timeline\_items. Completed items shown with green filled dots; incomplete with neutral dots; overdue items (due\_date in the past, completed = false) highlighted with the red color. Counselors can see the why\_text and what\_to\_do breakdown by tapping an item. A small "overdue" count badge appears on this tab if any items are past due.

Tab D — Counselor Notes: a private text field visible only to the counselor (not to the student). Persisted per student per counselor in the counselor\_notes table. No character limit; auto-saves on blur. The only screen in the counselor dashboard where the counselor writes anything.

#### Screen C3: At-Risk Flags and Priority Queue

A dedicated screen (accessible from the main nav) that surfaces students most in need of attention without requiring the counselor to manually scan every row.

Three sections:

1. Overdue Deadlines — students with at least one logistics timeline item where due\_date is past and completed = false. Sorted by most days overdue first. Each row shows: student name, grade, the specific overdue task title, how many days past due.
2. Stalled Profiles — students who completed onboarding but left 3+ optional profile fields empty and have not logged in within 14 days. Each row shows: student name, grade, which fields are missing, days since last login.

3. No School Matches — students who completed onboarding but have zero active school\_matches rows. Each row shows: student name, grade, days since onboarding.

Each student row across all three sections has a "Send Reminder" button that opens Screen C4.

#### Screen C4: Send Reminder

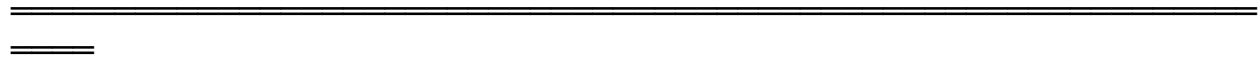
A simple message composer. Pre-filled templates counselors can edit before sending:

- Overdue deadline: "Hi [first name], you have a college application task coming up that's now overdue. Log in to kairos to check your timeline and mark it complete when done."
- Stalled profile: "Hi [first name], your kairos profile is missing a few details that would make your school matches and timeline more accurate. Log in when you have a few minutes and fill in what you can."
- No matches: "Hi [first name], it looks like your school match list may be empty. Log in to kairos and regenerate your list so you have a plan in place."

Counselors see a preview before sending. Sent reminders are logged in the reminder\_log table so counselors don't double-send.

#### Screen C5: Class-Level Aggregate View

A summary screen showing aggregate progress grouped by grade level. Four grade-level panels (Freshman, Sophomore, Junior, Senior), each showing: total students, % with a complete profile, % with an active school match list, % with at least one overdue timeline item, average number of schools on match lists. Shown as horizontal bar charts using the kairos design system. Read-only aggregate only; no individual student data shown on this screen.



#### MVP Prompt

#### kairos — Full MVP Build Specification

#### What kairos Is

kairos is a web platform that gives high school students personalized college admissions guidance. The mission is to give every student access to the kind of guidance a private college counselor would provide, regardless of whether their family can afford one.

This build includes two account types: students and counselors. The student experience is the

primary user flow. The counselor dashboard is also built in this MVP and gives school counselors a centralized view of their entire student caseload.

The student core experience: a student creates a profile, receives a personalized list of college matches with admission percentage estimates, receives a personalized timeline of deadlines and strategic advice, can get AI feedback on their essays, and can track everything in a living, auto-updating profile that functions like a resume.

The counselor core experience: a counselor logs in, sees their full roster of assigned students with status indicators, drills into any individual student's profile and timeline, flags at-risk students, and sends reminders via a built-in composer.

The product has two student-facing tiers: Free and Premium. Premium is \$12/month or \$120/year, billed via Stripe Checkout. Counselor access is not tier-gated on the student model; it is determined by the school license. The free tier must always feel genuinely useful on its own, not like a crippled demo, since the platform's core mission is about equity and access. Premium should feel like a meaningful upgrade, not a paywall on something that should obviously be free.

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## Tech Stack

- Frontend: Next.js (App Router), React
- Styling: Tailwind CSS
- Database & Auth: Supabase (Postgres + Supabase Auth)
- Hosting: Vercel
- AI: Anthropic API (Claude) for all generative features (school matching, timeline generation, essay feedback)
- Payments: Stripe Checkout for subscription handling (use standard Stripe Checkout flow, do not build custom billing logic)

---

## Design System (use exactly these values, do not substitute or "improve" them)

This is a dark-mode product. Do not default to a light theme.

```
--bg: #14121F;          /* main app background, near-black with violet undertone */
--card: #1F1B2E;        /* card/surface background, NOT pure white or pure black */
--primary: #8B7FE8;      /* primary purple, used for primary buttons, active states, links */
--primary-hover: #A99FF0; /* lighter purple, used for hover/active states (lighter, not darker,
since this is dark mode) */
```

--amber: #D4A24C; /\* gold accent, reserved specifically for: the "you are here" timeline marker, and key CTAs/highlights. Do not overuse this color elsewhere. \*/  
--amber-tint: #3A2F1C; /\* dark gold-brown background for amber-tinted UI elements (e.g. advice callout boxes) \*/  
--amber-text-on-tint: #E8C381; /\* light gold text color, used specifically for text sitting on top of amber-tint backgrounds \*/  
--green: #5BBE94; /\* success, safety schools, completed states \*/  
--green-tint: #1E332B;  
--red: #E08079; /\* reach schools, warnings \*/  
--red-tint: #3A2422;  
--premium: #B68FE8; /\* distinct lighter purple used ONLY for premium tags, locked states, and premium-specific UI. Must look visually distinct from --primary at a glance even though both are purple. \*/  
--premium-tint: #2E2444;  
--secondary: #5FBEDB; /\* blue, used for secondary/informational accents, not yet load-bearing for any specific feature in this MVP, use where a third accent color is needed \*/  
--secondary-tint: #1C313B;  
--text: #F0EEFA; /\* primary text color \*/  
--text-gray: #A39FC0; /\* secondary/muted text \*/  
--border: #322C48; /\* borders and dividers on dark surfaces \*/

Typography: Use a serif font (e.g. Georgia or a similar system serif) for headlines and screen titles, to give the product a slightly more human, thoughtful feel rather than a cold tech-startup feel. Use a standard system sans-serif for body text, labels, and UI elements. Do not use a serif font for body text or buttons.

General visual tone: calm, trustworthy, slightly premium, not flashy or game-like despite the dark background. Rounded corners (12–16px) on cards and buttons. Generous padding. Avoid dense, cramped layouts.

---

## Database Schema

Implement exactly these tables in Supabase. Do not add extra tables or fields beyond what's specified, and do not omit any field.

profiles (  
  user\_id uuid references auth.users primary key,  
  grade\_level text check (grade\_level in ('Freshman','Sophomore','Junior','Senior')) not null,  
  gpa decimal not null,  
  intended\_major text, -- nullable, optional  
  extracurriculars text[], -- nullable, optional



```

location_preference text, -- nullable, optional
college_goals text, -- nullable, optional
test_scores jsonb, -- nullable, optional, e.g. {"sat": 1350, "act": null}
subscription_tier text check (subscription_tier in ('free','premium')) default 'free' not null,
school_id uuid references schools(school_id), -- nullable, links student to a school for
counselor access
counselor_id uuid references counselors(counselor_id), -- nullable, links student to their
assigned counselor
last_login_at timestamptz, -- updated on each login, used by counselor dashboard to detect
inactivity
created_at timestamptz default now()
)

```

```

schools (
  school_id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
  name text not null,
  district text,
  license_tier text check (license_tier in ('small','medium','large','district')) not null,
  license_expiry date not null,
  created_at timestamptz default now()
)

```

```

counselors (
  counselor_id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
  user_id uuid references auth.users not null,
  school_id uuid references schools(school_id) not null,
  name text not null,
  email text not null,
  created_at timestamptz default now()
)

```

```

school_matches (
  id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
  user_id uuid references auth.users not null,
  school_name text not null,
  category text check (category in ('reach','target','safety')) not null,
  percentage int not null,
  why_text text not null,
  factors jsonb not null, -- structured object, see AI prompt schema below
  is_active boolean default true, -- soft delete flag when a student removes a school from their
list
  created_at timestamptz default now()
)

```

```

timeline_items (
  id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
  user_id uuid references auth.users not null,
  title text not null,
  due_date date, -- nullable. Must always be null for strategic_advice items (is_strategic = true)
  school_tags text[], -- which schools this item applies to
  tier text check (tier in ('free','premium')) not null,
  is_strategic boolean default false not null, -- true = strategic advice (premium feature), false =
logistics (free)
  completed boolean default false not null,
  profile_sync_field text, -- nullable, names which profiles field to update when this item is
marked complete
  why_text text not null,
  what_to_do jsonb not null, -- array of 2-4 string steps
  created_at timestamptz default now()
)

```

```

regeneration_log (
  user_id uuid references auth.users not null,
  week_start_date date not null,
  count int default 0 not null,
  primary key (user_id, week_start_date)
)

```

```

counselor_notes (
  id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
  counselor_id uuid references counselors(counselor_id) not null,
  student_user_id uuid references auth.users not null,
  note_text text,
  updated_at timestamptz default now()
)

```

```

reminder_log (
  id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
  counselor_id uuid references counselors(counselor_id) not null,
  student_user_id uuid references auth.users not null,
  message_text text not null,
  sent_at timestamptz default now()
)

```

Important: All AI-generated content (why\_text, factors, what\_to\_do) must be stored as structured JSON or well-typed columns, never as a single freeform text blob that would need to be parsed later. This matters specifically because the counselor dashboard needs to programmatically query things like "which students haven't completed their essay," and that's

only possible if the underlying data is structured now.

---

## Centralized Access Control

Two separate access control functions. Do not write checks inline anywhere else in the codebase.

```
// For student premium features
function canAccessFeature(user, featureKey) {
  // featureKey examples: 'career_path_explorer', 'essay_feedback', 'unlimited_regenerations',
  'strategic_timeline_advice'
  return user.subscription_tier === 'premium';
}

// For counselor routes — any route under /counselor/* must call this
function isCounselor(user) {
  return user.role === 'counselor'; // role is determined at login by checking the counselors table
}
```

---

## Screens: Student Flow (in order)

### Screen 0: Profile Completeness Popup

Shown as a bottom-sheet modal every time the app is opened, but only if the logged-in user's profile has any empty optional field (intended\_major, extracurriculars, location\_preference, college\_goals, or test\_scores).

Content:

- Title: "Your matches could be more accurate"
- Body: "A few parts of your profile are still missing, which means your school match percentages and timeline are based on incomplete information."
- A list of the specific missing fields by human-readable name, dynamically generated based on which fields are actually empty for that user.
- Two buttons: "Complete My Profile" (routes to the profile edit screen) and "Remind me later" (dismisses the modal for the current session only; it must reappear on the next app open if the fields are still incomplete)

This same missing-field-awareness pattern must also be reflected on the Percentage

Breakdown screen (Screen 4) whenever relevant data is missing there. Do not treat this popup as the only place this logic lives.

## Screen 1: Platform Introduction

Shown to first-time users before onboarding begins (not shown again after onboarding is complete).

Content:

- kairos wordmark/logo, set in the serif headline font, in the primary purple color
- Headline (serif, large): "College guidance shouldn't depend on what you can afford."
- Subtext (sans-serif, body size): "Stop guessing what to do next. kairos gives you total clarity, a personalized path built from your grades, goals, and interests, so you always know exactly what to focus on."
- A trust stat card displaying a live count, pulled from a real database query (count of rows in the profiles table), formatted as "[count] students helped so far" with a smaller subtext line "Real profiles, real plans, growing every week"
- A single primary CTA button: "Get Started", which begins onboarding

## Screen 2: Student Profile Onboarding

A single-step form collecting:

- Grade Level: dropdown, required. Options: Freshman, Sophomore, Junior, Senior
- Current GPA: numeric input, required
- Intended Major / Interests: free text input, optional
- Extracurriculars & Activities: free text input (can be comma-separated, parse into an array on submit), optional
- Location Preference: free text input, optional
- College Goals: free text input, optional

Critical requirement: the form must be submittable with only Grade Level and GPA filled in. Do not add client-side validation that blocks submission on the optional fields.

Above the form, show a small tip box with the text: "This builds your profile, which we'll use to generate your personalized school list and timeline next."

On submit, save to the profiles table and proceed automatically to school match list generation (Screen 3), showing a brief loading state while the AI call completes.

## Screen 3: School Match List

Generates and displays 15 schools total: 5 reach, 5 target, 5 safety, grouped into three clearly labeled sections in that order.

Each school card displays:

- School name (bold)
- Category pill (color-coded: reach = red/red-tint, target = amber/amber-tint, safety = green/green-tint)
- Admission percentage, displayed large and prominent, top-right of the card
- The why\_text (1-2 sentences explaining why this school was matched, referencing the student's actual input)
- A small "tap hint" line: "Tap % for the breakdown · Tap card for school info & career paths"

Interaction:

- Tapping the percentage number specifically navigates to the Percentage Breakdown screen (Screen 4) for that school
- Tapping anywhere else on the card navigates to the School Detail screen (Screen 5) for that school
- Students can remove a school from their list (this should set is\_active to false on that row, not hard-delete it)

At the top of the screen, include:

- A persistent reassurance line: "Built from your profile. Not set in stone, this evolves as you grow."
- A "Regenerate List" button and a counter showing remaining regenerations for the week ("Regenerations left this week: [n]")
- Free tier: capped at 3 regenerations per week, tracked via the regeneration\_log table
- Premium tier: unlimited regenerations, bypasses the cap entirely. Use canAccessFeature(user, 'unlimited\_regenerations') to determine whether to enforce the cap.

#### Screen 4: Percentage Breakdown

Reached by tapping a school's percentage on Screen 3. This screen is available on the Free tier.

Header: "How we calculated [percentage]%" followed by the school name and category.

Display exactly four factors, each as a labeled row with a horizontal progress bar:

1. GPA — show the student's GPA compared to that school's typical accepted GPA range, with a visual marker on the bar indicating where the "typical admit" falls relative to the student's bar fill
2. Course Rigor — a qualitative label (Strong / Moderate / Limited) derived from the student's course/extracurricular input
3. Extracurricular Strength — a qualitative label with a short explanatory note
4. Major Fit — a qualitative label showing alignment between the student's intended major and that school's program strengths

Hard requirement: every factor's accompanying text must end with a constructive,

forward-looking sentence, never a purely diagnostic one.

If any underlying profile data needed for a factor is missing, do not fabricate a value. Instead, display a note at the bottom of the screen with a tappable link that routes directly to the profile edit screen.

## Screen 5: School Detail

Two sub-tabs:

Tab A: "School Info" (default active tab, available on Free tier)

- A photo placeholder area (use a gradient placeholder if no real image source is integrated yet)
- A stats row showing: acceptance rate, founding year, student population
- An "About [School Name]" section with a 2-3 sentence description

Tab B: "Career Path" (Premium feature)

- If free tier: show a locked state with a lock icon, heading "Career Path is a Premium feature", explanatory body text, a "See Premium Plans" button routing to the Upgrade screen (Screen 10), and one dimmed preview card below
- If premium: show the real AI-generated career path content for the student's intended major at that specific school

## Screen 6: AI-Generated Timeline

This is the single most important screen in the product and must not be implemented as a flat checklist. Implement it as a vertical, connected timeline UI: a continuous vertical line running down the left side of the screen, with a small dot/node at each timeline item connecting to it.

Logistics items (Free tier):

- Deadlines and requirements merged across all of the student's matched schools
- Shared deadlines across multiple schools must be consolidated into a single timeline entry, not duplicated once per school
- School-specific or unique deadlines are shown as individual entries with a clear tag noting which school they belong to
- Each item can be checked off as complete

Strategic advice items (Premium tier):

- Proactive, profile-based recommendations tailored to the student's grade level and intended major
- These items are visually distinct: use the --premium-tint background and a dashed border style, and include a small "PREMIUM" tag/badge directly in the item
- If the logged-in user is on the free tier, these items must still appear in the timeline (do not hide them entirely), but in a locked/teaser state. Tapping the item routes to the Upgrade screen rather than the task detail screen.

- If the user is on premium, tapping a strategic advice item opens the full Task Detail screen

Use `canAccessFeature(user, 'strategic_timeline_advice')` to determine which state to render.

"You are here" marker (critical logic, implement exactly as specified):

Exactly one incomplete item on the timeline at any given time is visually marked as the current focus point, using the --amber gold color for its dot. Determine which item gets this marker using this exact priority order:

1. Among all incomplete items that have a `due_date`, select the one with the nearest upcoming date
2. If multiple incomplete items share the same nearest `due_date`, select whichever one has more entries in its `school_tags` array (i.e. affects the most schools)
3. Strategic advice items (`is_strategic = true`) must never receive the "you are here" marker, regardless of how the above logic would otherwise resolve

Task Detail screen: tapping any timeline item opens a detail view containing:

- The task title and due date at the top
- A "Why this matters" section: the `why_text` field
- A "What you can do" section: the `what_to_do` field, rendered as 2-4 distinct, concrete sub-steps
- A "Mark as Complete" button at the bottom

Profile Sync (implement exactly as specified, this is a core differentiating feature): when a timeline item is marked complete, if that item has a non-null `profile_sync_field` value, automatically update the corresponding field in the student's profiles row. This sync must happen automatically and immediately on completion, not as a separate manual step.

## Screen 7: Essay & Supplemental Feedback (Premium feature)

If free tier: show the same locked-state pattern used elsewhere in the app. Do not show a dead end or generic error.

If premium:

- A text input area where the student pastes or writes an essay draft
- A submit button that sends the draft to the Anthropic API using the essay feedback system prompt specified below
- The response is rendered as 3 to 5 distinct feedback cards, each with a short bolded label followed by 1-3 sentences of feedback text
- At least one of the returned cards must always be a positive/"what's working" observation

## Screen 8: Student Profile (Resume View)

A dedicated, always-accessible screen that displays the student's full profile in a resume-style

layout.

Layout:

- Header: student's name, grade level, GPA, and intended major, displayed prominently
- A stat strip showing: GPA, number of active schools on their match list, number of extracurriculars
- Section: "Classes" — split into "Completed" and "Upcoming" sub-lists
- Section: "Extracurriculars" — list with role/title and duration if available
- Section: "Internships & Research" — same pattern
- Section: "Achievements" — simple list
- An "Edit" button/link, allowing the student to manually update any field directly
- A footer note: "This profile updates automatically as you check off items on your timeline."

#### Screen 9: Upgrade (Free vs Premium Comparison)

This must be its own dedicated tab/route in the main navigation. It must also be reachable as a deep link from anywhere in the app that shows a locked premium feature (Screens 5, 6, 7).

Content:

- Two separately selectable pricing buttons, not a toggle switch: "\$12/month" and "\$120/year", with the yearly option visually labeled to highlight the savings (e.g. "2 months free")
  - A comparison table with these exact rows: Profile & timeline (✓ free / ✓ premium), School match list (✓ / ✓), Tailored advice on percentages (✓ / ✓), List regenerations (3/week / Unlimited), Career path explorer (— / ✓), Essay feedback tool (— / ✓)
  - A short explanatory paragraph, framed constructively rather than as a sales pitch: "The free tier covers everything you need to build a real plan. Premium adds the deeper, more personal tools, like essay coaching and career exploration, for when you're ready to go further."
  - Selecting a plan initiates Stripe Checkout for that plan
- 

#### Screens: Counselor Flow (in order)

All counselor routes live under `/counselor/*` and are guarded by `isCounselor(user)`. A logged-in student who navigates to a `/counselor/*` route must be redirected to the student app, not shown an error or blank screen.

#### Screen C1: Counselor Home — Student Roster Overview

The counselor's landing screen. A bird's-eye view of their entire assigned caseload.

Layout:

- A header stat strip showing: total students assigned, number with incomplete profiles, number



with no active school match list yet, number with at least one overdue timeline item

- A filterable, sortable student list. Each row shows: student name, grade level, GPA, number of active matched schools, number of incomplete timeline items, and a status badge (one of: On Track, Needs Attention, No Activity)

Status badge logic (implement exactly as specified):

- "On Track": student has a complete profile, at least one active school match, and no overdue logistics timeline items

- "Needs Attention": student has an overdue logistics deadline, an incomplete profile with no activity in 14+ days, or zero active school matches after completing onboarding

- "No Activity": student completed onboarding but has not logged in within the past 30 days

Filtering: by grade level (Freshman, Sophomore, Junior, Senior), by status badge, by college goal keyword (free text search against the college\_goals field)

Sorting: by nearest upcoming deadline (default), by last login date ascending (so least-recently-active students surface first), by GPA ascending or descending

Tapping a student row navigates to Screen C2 for that student.

## Screen C2: Student Detail View

A read-only counselor view of an individual student's full profile and progress. Counselors cannot edit student data directly; they can view and annotate.

Four tabs at the top:

Tab A — Profile: mirrors the student's Screen 8 (Resume View) data exactly. Shows which fields are still empty, highlighted with a subtle warning indicator. Read-only.

Tab B — School Matches: lists all active school\_matches rows for this student, same Reach/Target/Safety groupings and percentage display as Screen 3. Counselors can see the why\_text and factors breakdown for each school. Read-only; counselors cannot add or remove schools from a student's list in this MVP.

Tab C — Timeline: full read-only view of the student's timeline\_items. Completed items shown with green filled dots; incomplete items with neutral dots; overdue items (due\_date in the past, completed = false) highlighted with the --red color. Counselors can see the why\_text and what\_to\_do breakdown for any item by tapping it. A small "overdue" count badge appears on this tab if any items are past due.

Tab D — Counselor Notes: a private text field visible only to the counselor (not to the student). Persisted per student per counselor in the counselor\_notes table. No character limit; auto-saves on blur. Intended for meeting notes, observations, or flags. This is the only screen in the counselor dashboard where the counselor writes anything.

### Screen C3: At-Risk Flags and Priority Queue

A dedicated screen (accessible from the main counselor nav) that surfaces the students most in need of attention without requiring the counselor to manually scan every row.

Three sections, each showing a ranked student list:

1. Overdue Deadlines: students with at least one logistics timeline item where `due_date` is in the past and `completed = false`. Sorted by how many days overdue the nearest missed deadline is (most overdue first). Each row shows: student name, grade, the specific overdue task title, and how many days past due.

2. Stalled Profiles: students who completed onboarding but have left 3 or more optional profile fields empty and have not logged in within the past 14 days. Each row shows: student name, grade, which specific fields are missing, days since last login.

3. No School Matches: students who completed onboarding but have zero active `school_matches` rows. Each row shows: student name, grade, days since onboarding completed.

Each student row across all three sections has a "Send Reminder" button that opens Screen C4 pre-populated for that student.

### Screen C4: Send Reminder

A simple message composer allowing counselors to send a nudge to a specific student via email (using the student's account email from `auth.users`).

Pre-filled templates (counselor can edit before sending):

- Overdue deadline: "Hi [first name], you have a college application task coming up that's now overdue. Log in to kairos to check your timeline and mark it complete when done."
- Stalled profile: "Hi [first name], your kairos profile is missing a few details that would make your school matches and timeline more accurate. Log in when you have a few minutes and fill in what you can."
- No matches: "Hi [first name], it looks like your school match list may be empty. Log in to kairos and regenerate your list so you have a plan in place."

The counselor sees a preview of the final message before sending. Sending does not require the counselor to write anything from scratch, but they can edit the template freely.

Sent reminders are logged in the `reminder_log` table so counselors don't double-send and can reference their outreach history.

## Screen C5: Class-Level Aggregate View

A summary screen showing aggregate progress across all students in the counselor's caseload, grouped by grade level.

Four grade-level panels (Freshman, Sophomore, Junior, Senior), each showing:

- Total students in that grade
- % with a complete profile (all optional fields filled)
- % with an active school match list
- % with at least one overdue timeline item
- Average number of schools on their match lists

A simple horizontal bar chart for each metric, styled in the kairos design system (using --primary for filled bars, --border for empty bars). This screen is read-only and aggregate only; no individual student data is shown on this screen.

---

AI System Prompts (use these exactly, do not paraphrase or shorten them)

School Matching (used on Screen 3)

You are generating a college match list for a high school student. You will be given their GPA, grade level, intended major, extracurriculars, location preference, college goals, and test scores. Some of these fields may be missing; if so, you will be told explicitly which ones are missing.

Return exactly 15 schools: 5 categorized as "reach", 5 as "target", and 5 as "safety".

For each school, return:

- name: the school's full name
- category: "reach", "target", or "safety"
- percentage: an estimated admission percentage as an integer, grounded in that school's real general acceptance rate and typical admitted student profile (GPA range, test scores, etc.), not an arbitrary number
- why\_text: one sentence explaining why this school was matched, explicitly referencing the specific student input it's based on (e.g. their GPA, their stated major, their location preference)
- factors: an object containing four fields: gpa\_comparison, course\_rigor, ec\_strength, major\_fit. Each field's value must be a short assessment that ends with one constructive, forward-looking sentence. Never end a factor assessment purely diagnostically (i.e. never just state a gap without also stating what would help close it).

If any input field needed to assess a given factor is missing, explicitly state in that factor's value which input was unavailable, and do not fabricate an assessment for it.

Return your response as JSON matching this exact structure:

```
{
  "schools": [
    {
      "name": "string",
      "category": "reach" | "target" | "safety",
      "percentage": integer,
      "why_text": "string",
      "factors": {
        "gpa_comparison": "string",
        "course_rigor": "string",
        "ec_strength": "string",
        "major_fit": "string"
      }
    }
  ]
}
```

#### Timeline Generation (used on Screen 6)

You are generating a personalized college admissions timeline for a high school student, given their full profile and their list of currently matched schools (with names and categories).

Return two separate arrays:

1. "logistics": deadlines and requirements merged across the student's matched schools. Consolidate any deadline shared by multiple schools into a single entry rather than duplicating it once per school. Flag deadlines that are unique to a specific school as individual entries.
2. "strategic\_advice": proactive, non-deadline-driven recommendations (such as specific coursework, internships, or extracurricular activities) tailored specifically to the student's grade level and intended major.

Each item in either array must include:

- title: short task name
- due\_date: a date string, or null. strategic\_advice items must always have due\_date set to null, with no exceptions.
- school\_tags: an array of school names this item is relevant to (can be empty for general strategic advice not tied to specific schools)
- why\_text: one to two sentences explaining why this item matters, referencing the student's actual schools or stated goals where relevant, not generic language
- what\_to\_do: an array of 2 to 4 short, concrete, specific sub-steps the student can take regarding this item

Return your response as JSON matching this exact structure:

```
{
  "logistics": [
    { "title": "string", "due_date": "YYYY-MM-DD" | null, "school_tags": ["string"], "why_text":
"string", "what_to_do": ["string"] }
  ],
  "strategic_advice": [
    { "title": "string", "due_date": null, "school_tags": ["string"], "why_text": "string", "what_to_do":
["string"] }
  ]
}
```

### Essay Feedback (used on Screen 7)

You are reviewing a college application essay draft written by a high school student. Your role is to give direct, honest feedback that challenges the student to be more specific and authentic in their writing, rather than offering generic praise or vague encouragement.

Specifically look for: generic phrases that any applicant could have written, unearned or unsupported emotional claims, places where the student is summarizing an experience rather than showing a specific moment from it, and any other instances of vague or surface-level writing.

You must always include at least one genuine, specific "what's working" observation about the essay, so the feedback is not purely critical. Do not invent a positive observation if none exists; find something real and specific, even if the overall draft needs significant work.

Do not rewrite any part of the essay yourself. Only point to what needs to change and explain why.

Return 3 to 5 distinct feedback items as JSON matching this exact structure:

```
{
  "feedback": [
    { "label": "string (e.g. 'Be more specific')", "text": "string (1-3 sentences)" }
  ]
}
```

---

### Error States, Loading States, and Edge Cases

Do not leave these implicit. Implement exactly as specified.

AI call failures (school matching, timeline generation, essay feedback, career path): If any Anthropic API call fails or times out, do not show a blank screen and do not fabricate placeholder data that looks real. Show a simple message (e.g. "Something went wrong generating this. Try again.") with a retry button that re-triggers the same call.

Loading states for AI calls: While waiting for school match list or timeline generation, show a loading state with brief explanatory text (e.g. "Building your personalized list..." or "Mapping out your timeline..."), not a generic spinner with no context.

Responsive design: Every screen in this spec must work cleanly on mobile viewport widths first, then scale up to desktop. This is not optional polish, the majority of real users will be on a phone. Pay particular attention to the Timeline screen (Screen 6), since its vertical connected-line layout is the most complex to get right responsively, and to the Percentage Breakdown screen (Screen 4), since its factor bars need to remain legible at narrow widths.

Stripe Checkout completion: After a user completes Stripe Checkout successfully, a webhook must update that user's `subscription_tier` field in the profiles table to 'premium'. Do not rely on a client-side redirect alone to "unlock" premium, since that can be bypassed or fail silently; the source of truth must be the webhook-driven database update. If a subscription is later canceled or fails to renew, the same webhook pattern should revert `subscription_tier` back to 'free'.

Auth and session edge cases:

- Any protected student route (anything beyond Screen 1) accessed by a logged-out user must redirect to login, not show a broken or partial page
- Any `/counselor/*` route accessed by a logged-out user must redirect to login
- Any `/counselor/*` route accessed by a logged-in student must redirect to the student app
- If a user closes the app partway through onboarding (Screen 2) before submitting, their partial input is not saved; they restart onboarding from the beginning on next login. Do not attempt to build partial-save/resume logic for onboarding in this MVP
- A user who has already completed onboarding must never see the onboarding flow again on subsequent logins; route them directly to the School Match List screen

---

Do not build any of the following, even if they seem like natural extensions of features described above:

- Scholarship matching or FAFSA-specific tracking beyond the generic deadline entries already described in the timeline
- A parent-facing account type or portal
- Integration with Canvas, Schoology, or any other LMS
- Any custom billing logic beyond standard Stripe Checkout
- District-level administrator dashboard or multi-school reporting

- The ability for counselors to edit student profiles directly
- The ability for counselors to add or remove schools from a student's match list

If you find yourself about to build something not explicitly described in this document, stop and flag it rather than proceeding on your own judgment.

# Meeting With CC Salzman



## **1. Set the Context**

## **2. Explain the Problem & Vision**

- My immediate goal is to have around 100 active users

## **3. Product Walkthrough**

## **4. Strategic Discussion**

The goal here isn't to collect opinions—it's to learn how an experienced founder would think about building kairos from where you are today.

### **Go-to-Market & Customer Acquisition**

- If you were trying to get the first 100 users, how would you approach it?
  - She would use Reddit
    - Go on college counseling forums and post this
    - Run Reddit Ads
  - TikTok
  - Facebook Ads
  - Instagram
  - Twitter
  - LinkedIn doesn't have the right target audience
- At what point would you stop building and focus almost entirely on distribution?
  - Never fully stop building
  - You're always going to be iterating
  - Cohort analysis
    - Figuring out when people drop off
    - [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cohort\\_analysis](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cohort_analysis)

### **Scaling the Business**

- Assuming people genuinely love the product, how would you go about scaling it?
  - I'm going to want partnerships
  - Send it to the entire debate group or basketball team or football team

### **Fundraising & Company Building**

- Would you recommend applying to startup accelerators like YC, or should I wait until we have more traction?
  - For me it could be very necessary, more likely to get in when I apply the second time
  - Doing a tech product

- Resources and exposure
- If yes, what milestones would you want to hit before applying to an accelerator or raising money?
  - No
- If yes, if you were evaluating this for an accelerator, what would you want to see before saying yes?
  -

### **Founder Perspective**

- If this were your company, what would your priorities be over the next six months?
  - Just build and get customers
  - Change in motion

### **Network & Opportunities**

- Is there anyone you think I should meet who could meaningfully help kairos?
  - Ponzi scheme users
- Ask for Shivam's email

# Meeting With Nikhil

- **Which of the application questions did you spend the most time on, and which mattered less than you expected?**
  - They're not looking to see if your idea is the next \$100 billion dollar idea
  - Idea matters less, more about how deeply you've thought about it
  - How much do you know about your market, what evidence have I collected
  - **\*\*Why is it that people want my product\*\***
  - The key is to show my depth of thinking
  
- **As a solo, high-school-age founder, how should I handle the founder-background questions when I don't have a typical resume?**
  - I should be explicit, like yes I'm young
    - What advantage does that give me
      - I'm scrappy
      - I am my target audience
      - I have extra time
  
- **What's a strong versus weak answer to "how do you know people need what you're making" when I don't have paying users yet?**
  - A really strong answer would be that I have a 50 person data group ready to go
    - Or a huge waitlist
    - Do I have a big enough demand?
  - The market already supports private college counselors
  - Find lots of data on how many people use actual college counseling
  - 20 colleges \* \$200 fee, is people willing to pay \$4000
  - Create virality
    - Make an invite code
  
- **What's your own answer to the "hacked a non-computer system" question, and what made it work?**
  - He ended up getting a ton of credit card points
  - Venmo would let him transfer via credit card and would send to friends back and forth to stack credit points
  - Are you curious enough to identify some sort of arbitrage
  - Talk about my love for the hustle
  - I love that I can make value out of nothing
  - Prime story
  
- **How much does the founder video actually matter relative to the written answers, and what makes one land well?**
  - Record something that's passionate and convincing
  - Give them the story of how there are extremely wealthy students who can afford private counseling but also a lot of students who can't afford

- Come in and say there is a need and that I see it on a daily basis
- Say that I don't care about YC, I'm applying to help me scale this business but I'm going to keep doing it no matter what

**Notes:**

- Barely any people are successful selling EdTech to schools
- Their level of success is questionable
- I should just pick one
  - Sounds like I should build the student platform much more
  - That's my unique advantage
- YC isn't the goal, it's a step
-

# Focus Group Synthesis

KAIROS FOCUS GROUP SYNTHESIS Participants: Ahana, Caroline, Jake, Tahir

**BACKGROUND: COUNSELOR STATUS** Ahana is the only participant with a counselor (Marci), found through a family referral (her sister's counselor). First meeting was purely a get-to-know-you — no advice yet. She initiates contact monthly via email, then a meeting. She likes that Marci is organized, responds fast, and proactively flags opportunities that match her interests. Her one ask: more counselor-initiated outreach.

Caroline, Jake, and Tahir don't have counselors yet, but all three sets of parents have independently landed on "end of sophomore year" as the start point. This is a clean signal for when the get-a-counselor decision actually triggers in a household.

**EMOTIONAL ENTRY POINT** "College applications" triggers overwhelm and not knowing where to start (Jake, echoed by Ahana). Caroline's stress is rooted in not knowing herself yet — she's only seen big schools and has no read on preferences like weather or environment, so her anxiety is a self-knowledge gap, not a logistics gap. Tahir associates the phrase with "preparation."

Implication: the product's emotional job is turning ambiguity into structure. Caroline's framing specifically argues for a self-discovery/preferences step before school matching, not just a timeline.

**TOP THINGS A COUNSELOR SHOULD HELP WITH** Consistent across all four, roughly in order of frequency:

1. Roadmap/timeline — what to do, when, how. Prevents cramming everything into one month (Ahana specifically flagged this).
2. Narrowing down the school list — target/reach/safety fit, independently raised as the #1 priority by Jake, Ahana, and Tahir.
3. Essay support — prompts, grading, feedback. Likely the single most-mentioned feature across all the sticky-note exercises.
4. Major/course guidance tied to goals — "which courses get me to my goals," "majors I'd be interested in."
5. Secondary tier: activity evaluation, recommendation letters, mock interviews, SAT/ACT roadmap and tutoring.

Tahir specifically wants the counselor to break goals into milestones and act as an unbiased outside party to sanity-check decisions — his framing of value is neutrality, not just knowledge.

**WHERE THEY'D WANT TO START / DESIRED COUNSELOR ATTRIBUTES** Jake: big picture first, then a breakdown of steps. Ahana: build a plan, set goals. Caroline: counselor gets to know her first, for fit. Tahir: narrow down interests/fields before "getting down to business."

All four independently want a discovery/get-to-know-you phase before any recommendations — this validates gating match generation behind real onboarding rather than jumping straight from quiz to results.

Desired attributes: Jake wants organized, good track record, responsive. Ahana wants innovative and adaptable. Caroline wants bubbly, friendly, relatable to her. Tahir wants proven and organized, but relationship-first before transactional.

AI TRUST (the most load-bearing finding in the session) All four already use AI (ChatGPT/Claude) for ideas, vocab, math help, and second opinions — none of them frame that use as cheating.

Jake: AI opens doors to cheating but genuinely helps generate ideas; worried about false information steering him off course. Ahana: beneficial for learning (vocab, math) but would never use AI to write her application — fear of detection flagging leading to a rescinded acceptance. Caroline: agrees with Ahana — AI writes distinguishably from humans and is easy to flag. Separately noted AI tools are easy to use with no instructions needed, and that her dad uses a lot of AI apps (a normalization signal). Tahir: sees AI as a second teacher or peer, useful for new ideas, but self-imposes a boundary so he doesn't outsource his own thinking.

Trust-builders raised on paper notes: track record, real/secondary research, a fact-checker, showing where recommendations came from.

Product implication: essay/narrative tools need to be visibly positioned as coaching — prompts, grading, structural feedback — and explicitly not drafting. Recommendations should show their sourcing rather than just asserting an answer.

## PROTOTYPE FEEDBACK BY SCREEN

Chat screen — the interface currently "looks like GPT" (flagged twice independently) — reads as generic rather than purpose-built for college admissions. Feedback: change the color palette, reduce visual busyness, avoid bland/wordy copy, add more visual weight, surface context earlier in the flow rather than mid-conversation.

Onboarding — should include imagery per screen (consistent with existing design requirements). Don't re-ask info already collected; move name/location/highlights into the 2nd onboarding step; keep page count down (one note flagged the current flow as too long).

Matches (7 rounds of questions) — reaction was mixed-positive, not fatigue. Moderator scored the matches setup 6–8/10 depending on the note ("visuals are great," "loads fast"), but the AI chat step itself scored low, 5/10 — "too few/generic questions," "shouldn't just generate a list without more context." The complaint was about question quality and specificity, not question volume.

Timeline — repeatedly requested as its own view: due dates, how far along the student is, test dates. Feature request: sync/edit and match visuals to a calendar.



Feature prioritization — top 3 clustered around:

1. Essay help (prompts, grading, feedback)
2. Timeline/roadmap tied to goals
3. School matching based on preferences Narrative Builder was specifically valued for surfacing "what more you can do" — gap-finding in a student's own story.

AI coach vs. doing the work — consistent with the trust section: fine to generate prompts, structure, and critique; not fine to draft. This should be stated explicitly in product copy, not just held as an internal design principle, since three of four participants raised the rescinded-acceptance fear unprompted.

WRAP-UP SIGNALS Participants leaned toward using Kairos alongside a human counselor rather than as a full replacement, consistent with the "second opinion / unbiased outside party" language used throughout (especially by Tahir). Overall prototype sentiment was positive but not yet differentiated — 7-8/10 on structure and usefulness, dragged down by the chat/question step feeling generic and the visual style reading as "another ChatGPT."

#### TOP 3 PRODUCT PRIORITIES

1. Fix the chat/questions step — it's the single lowest-scored element (5/10) and the most explicitly criticized ("too generic," "looks like GPT"). Sharpening question specificity and giving the interface its own visual identity is the highest-leverage fix.
2. Ship/refine the timeline as a first-class, calendar-synced view — the most consistently requested feature across every exercise in the session.
3. State the AI boundary explicitly in essay/narrative copy — coach, not ghostwriter — since the rescinded-acceptance fear came up unprompted from 3 of 4 participants and is the biggest adoption blocker for the most trust-sensitive feature set.